

Reaching the surface

Magma that reaches the Earth's surface is called lava. It cools quickly and solidifies into other types of igneous rock, such as basalt. Eventually, the rocks are eroded by the weather and taken toward the sea, and the rock cycle begins again.

Rain, wind, and frost

Stormy clouds carry rain, sleet, and snow that over time cause rock to weaken and break up. Windy weather also helps break up rocks.

Ice in glaciers melts into rivers and streams that carry pieces of rock to the sea.

Magma can also cool and slowly become solid underground. This creates some types of igneous rock, such as granite.

Wearing away

Rocks are carried away by a river, glacier, or winds and are gradually broken up into smaller pieces.

Beaches are created when tiny broken pieces of rock build up at the coast.

Magma

If the heat is very intense, sedimentary and metamorphic rocks can turn into hot liquid rock, called magma. This can burst through the surface in a volcanic eruption.

Heat and pressure

When sedimentary rock travels deep inside the Earth, it is put under a lot of pressure and reaches temperatures of about 400°F (200°C). This heat and pressure turn it into metamorphic rock.

Sedimentary rock changes to become metamorphic at depths of roughly 6 miles (10 km) below Earth's surface.